of a hotel room was never going to be ideal, but it was a whole lot better than being apart.

It had been a stressful period: limited-overs success and the 3–0 Test series defeat in India, the 2–1 Test series lost at home to England followed by some limited-overs success, and then our failure to reach the last four of the ICC World Twenty20 ... and I looked forward to being revived by RCB in particular and by India in general.

In 2016, as in the five previous IPL tournaments, our team was known for three top-order batsmen – Kohli, Gayle and De Villiers – and an inexperienced bowling attack; this apparent imbalance was exacerbated when key bowlers Mitchell Starc and new signing Samuel Badree had to withdraw, injured, just before the tournament.

So we started our campaign, unsure about our ability to contain top-class opposing batsmen and believing that, whatever happened when we were fielding, we would just have to score more runs.

We started as we meant to go on, batting first and scoring 227 for four against Sunrisers Hyderabad. Virat Kohli and I added 157 for the second wicket, and I was pleased to be back at the Chinnaswamy, pleased to be hitting the ball cleanly, pleased to be contributing 82 runs to what unfolded as an encouraging victory.

Virat was in the form of his life, placing the ball brilliantly, driving magnificently through and over the covers, efficiently clipping anything fractionally off line through the leg side, brutally pulling anything remotely short to or over the boundary between square leg and long-on. His abundance of skill and talent was wrapped in a raw passion to score runs, and more runs, and a vein-busting determination to win.

IPL 9 would become a platform for what, in my assessment, was one of the most sustained periods of consistent brilliance in the history of our game. In the 14 group matches played by RCB, Virat scored an unimaginable and almost certainly unrepeatable 919 runs, including four centuries and six 50s at a strike rate of 151.70.